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Emotional Tone and Fundraising Success

A GoFundMe text analysis using the GALC and EmoLex dictionaries in SEANCE

Data overview

I examined whether the emotional tone of GoFundMe campaign descriptions was linked to fundraising success. I began with 1,242 campaigns. I removed 11 records because they had missing or unusable key information. This left 1,231 descriptions for text analysis. Of these campaigns, 455 (37.0%) met or passed their fundraising goals. The median campaign raised 87.47% of its goal.

Table 1. Overview of the campaign data

Measure	Value
Campaigns in the original dataset	1,242
Campaigns used for SEANCE	1,231
Records removed during cleaning	11
Mean length of campaign descriptions	62.75 words
Campaigns reaching or passing goal	455 (37.0%)
Median percentage of goal raised	87.47%

Preprocessing and text analysis

I first prepared the fundraising data. I changed amounts raised, goals, donor counts, GoFundMe hearts, and Facebook shares into numbers. For example, I changed “1.0M” into 1,000,000. I converted campaign duration into days and treated one month as 30 days. I calculated Percent_Raised as 100 × amount raised ÷ goal. For the descriptions, I removed web links, HTML tags, and extra spaces. I kept useful words, including “not,” so I would not lose simple negative meanings.

I saved each cleaned description as a separate text file. I then used the Sentiment Analysis and Cognition Engine (SEANCE). This tool uses predefined lists of emotion-related words. I first explored the GALC dictionary. Later, I repeated the analysis using both GALC and EmoLex. I matched the emotion scores to the fundraising records by Campaign_ID. All 1,231 descriptions matched correctly.

How I defined the constructs and chose the dictionaries

I had a broad idea of emotional tone at the start, but I had not fixed four specific emotions before my first SEANCE run. I used GALC as an exploratory first step and then chose four categories that made sense for fundraising. Feeling love refers to caring or connection. Gratitude refers to appreciation for help. Hope reflects a positive expectation that a difficult situation may improve. Anger can express unfairness or urgency. For the additional analysis, I focused on trust (confidence), anticipation (expectations about the future), sadness (hardship or loss), and fear (danger or worry). I chose EmoLex because it has predefined word lists for these four concepts. These choices were guided by meaning, not by which p-values looked best. Because my exact categories were refined during the analysis, I treat the tests as exploratory, not as proof of a theory. Each score reflects the share of analyzed words that match a dictionary, not the feelings of donors.

Table 2. Emotional words detected by the two dictionaries

GALC emotion	Campaigns with match	EmoLex emotion	Campaigns with match
Feeling love	375 (30.46%)	Trust	1,132 (91.96%)
Gratitude	112 (9.10%)	Anticipation	1,030 (83.67%)
Hope	66 (5.36%)	Sadness	715 (58.08%)
Anger	67 (5.44%)	Fear	820 (66.61%)

Note. The side-by-side rows are for display only; they do not represent equivalent emotions. A nonzero score means SEANCE found at least one matching dictionary word.

Regression approach

I estimated two ordinary least squares (OLS) models for each dictionary. Model A predicts Percent_Raised. I left out the 12 campaigns with goals of $1 or $2, because these gave unusually large percentages. Model B predicts Number_of_Donators. In both models, I used four emotional scores, GoFundMe hearts, Facebook shares, and campaign duration in days. I also removed rows with missing model values. I used HC3 robust standard errors to report the results. The final samples were 1,181 campaigns for Model A and 1,192 for Model B.

Main regression results

Table 3. GALC regression results

Predictor	Model A: b (SE)	p	Model B: b (SE)	p
Intercept	172.82 (37.97)	<0.001	-2.75 (10.83)	0.800
Feeling Love	2,798.62 (1,906.46)	0.142	50.78 (152.78)	0.740
Gratitude	5,433.67 (4,852.59)	0.263	38.77 (228.61)	0.865
Hope	-1,544.65 (1,691.07)	0.361	67.36 (182.13)	0.711
Anger	3,368.85 (3,871.84)	0.384	-166.39 (341.37)	0.626
GFM Hearts	0.0030 (0.0172)	0.860	0.9992 (0.0081)	<0.001
Facebook Shares	0.0103 (0.0082)	0.211	-0.0052 (0.0040)	0.191
Duration (days)	-0.7735 (0.3054)	0.011	0.0525 (0.0653)	0.421

GALC: Model A N = 1,181, R^2 = 0.0293; Model B N = 1,192, R^2 = 0.9973.

Table 4. EmoLex regression results

Predictor	Model A: b (SE)	p	Model B: b (SE)	p
Intercept	269.28 (59.67)	<0.001	2.51 (9.89)	0.800
Trust	-452.21 (330.49)	0.1712	-105.53 (104.02)	0.3104
Anticipation	-734.15 (390.76)	0.0603	-87.09 (80.20)	0.2775
Sadness	-411.64 (482.63)	0.3937	-52.54 (196.30)	0.7890
Fear	-356.13 (639.04)	0.5773	153.37 (91.24)	0.0928
GoFundMe Hearts	0.0031 (0.0167)	0.8515	0.9993 (0.0081)	<0.001
Facebook Shares	0.0101 (0.0084)	0.2295	-0.0054 (0.0041)	0.1867
Fundraising Duration	-0.8256 (0.3265)	0.0114	0.0547 (0.0637)	0.3898

EmoLex: Model A N = 1,181, R^2 = 0.0247; Model B N = 1,192, R^2 = 0.9973. All coefficients are unstandardized; SEs are HC3 robust. I used $p < 0.05$ to judge statistical significance.

In Model A, I did not find any statistically significant emotion scores in either dictionary. GALC explained 2.93% of the variation in funding percentage. EmoLex explained 2.47%. Fundraising duration was negative and significant in both models (GALC: b = -0.7735, p = 0.011; EmoLex: b = -0.8256, p = 0.011). This is an association, not proof that longer campaigns raise less money.

In Model B, I again found no significant emotional scores. GoFundMe hearts was the strongest predictor in both models ($b \approx 0.999$, $p < 0.001$). Both models had R^2 close to 0.9973. I treated this result with care because hearts and donor counts were almost perfectly correlated ($r = 0.9986$).

Sensitivity checks and model comparison

I also checked whether a few unusual values had too much influence. For Model A, I excluded the highest 1% of fundraising percentages. For Model B, I ran both dictionaries again without GoFundMe hearts. I kept the same campaigns for each comparison.

Table 5. Comparison of main models and sensitivity checks

Dictionary	Outcome	Specification	N	R^2	Significant predictor
GALC	A: % raised	Main	1,181	0.0293	Duration (−)
EmoLex	A: % raised	Main	1,181	0.0247	Duration (−)
GALC	B: donors	Main	1,192	0.9973	Hearts (+)
EmoLex	B: donors	Main	1,192	0.9973	Hearts (+)
GALC	A: % raised	Top 1% excluded	1,169	0.0163	Duration (−)
EmoLex	A: % raised	Top 1% excluded	1,169	0.0094	Duration (−)
GALC	B: donors	No hearts	1,192	0.5616	FB shares (+)
EmoLex	B: donors	No hearts	1,192	0.5642	FB shares (+)

Note. In all eight models, none of the selected emotional constructs reached $p < 0.05$. "Significant predictor" shows the significant non-emotional variable; (+)/(−) indicates its coefficient sign.

Key findings and interpretation

My main finding was the same for GALC and EmoLex. I did not find a statistically significant link between any of the selected emotional scores and fundraising success or donor count after including the other variables. In the EmoLex model for percentage raised, anticipation had $p = 0.060$. In its donor model, fear had $p = 0.093$. These values are close to, but still above, 0.05. I did not treat them as significant results.

EmoLex found more emotion-related words than several of my GALC measures. For example, EmoLex trust appeared in 1,132 campaigns, while GALC hope appeared in only 66. Even so, the EmoLex models did not find stronger evidence for emotional effects. This tells me that finding more emotion words does not automatically mean those scores explain fundraising outcomes. It does not mean that the feelings behind a story are unimportant to donors.

After I excluded the highest 1% of funding percentages, Model A R^2 dropped to 0.0163 for GALC and 0.0094 for EmoLex. Duration remained negative and significant in both models (about -0.176 and -0.178 percentage points per day). The emotional scores were still not significant. Some coefficients changed direction, so I would not rely on their signs alone.

When I removed hearts from Model B, R^2 dropped to 0.5616 for GALC and 0.5642 for EmoLex. Facebook shares became positively associated with donor count in both models (GALC: $b = 0.2899$; EmoLex: $b = 0.2897$; both $p < 0.001$). I cannot say sharing caused more donations. Successful campaigns may also attract more shares.

Limits and conclusion

I see several limits in this study. Descriptions were short and sometimes seemed cut off. Dictionary scores count matching words, but may miss the meaning of a full story. Fundraising percentages and donor counts were highly uneven. The near-duplicate hearts and donor measures also made the main donor models look much stronger than they really were for studying emotions. Since I used observational data, I cannot show cause and effect. Overall, I found no clear evidence that my selected GALC or EmoLex emotion scores predicted fundraising outcomes. Duration and social engagement showed more consistent statistical patterns in this dataset.